highest in the world by the end of century. The KVD-1 was first test-fired in June 1967 and was tested for 24,000 seconds in six starts. Five live engines were tested over the years 1974-75 (some were made even after the manned lunar programme had been cancelled). This small object was to spark off international controversy.

The KVD-1 was not a new motor – it was originally developed as part of the Soviet manned moon landing programme as far back as 1964. Under Vasili Mishin's plan, the KVD-1 would have been used to land a Soviet lunar module able to sustain a team of cosmonauts for a month. However, the KVD-1 never flew and was placed in storage.

We struck the deal with Glavkosmos. There were no prizes for guessing who will be upset about a technology transfer from Russia to India; and we expected the worst.

By early 1991, the Soviet Union, the only geopolitical counter power to the US, was on the brink of a collapse, with Russia preparing to secede from the Union. The cold war had long ended and Mikhael Gorbachev, having experimented with Perestroika and Glasnost, was throwing his hands up at the imminent disintegration of the union, while the Americans were 'rubbing their hands in glee,' as the last Soviet leader would say twenty-five years later in an interaction to the British media.

The imminent fall of the Soviet Union meant the Americans would arm-twist Russia into subservience. Besides this, I had a reason to be restless. I was to retire in 2001. I wanted to use the Russian technology to develop a cryogenic engine that can put into orbit a payload of at least two tonnes by 1999, and then upgrade it to four tonnes.

We signed the Russian deal on 18 January 1991. Under this, Glavkosmos was to give us four KVD-1 engines and transfer the technology. For this, Russian engineers were to work with us for the transfer or 'know-why' besides giving us drawings, mock-up models, instruments and materials to build the engine. There were milestones built into the contract, spelling out the instalments of transfer against payments.

Four engines from the stockpile were peanuts for the Russians, though now they were in a severe financial crisis because of the plunging rouble.